

India's Growth Story
Women at the Heart of a Changing Nation

Women are shaping India's growth story across boardrooms, classrooms, hospitals, government offices, laboratories and marketplaces. From the doctor serving patients and the teacher shaping young minds to the entrepreneur creating jobs and the civil servant driving governance, women are increasingly moving from being participants in India's development to becoming its architects.

The transformation is visible in workforce numbers. India's female Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR) for those aged 15 years and above rose from 23.3% in 2017-18 to 41.7% in 2023-24, while the female Worker Population Ratio increased from 22% to 40.3%. Female unemployment fell from 5.6% to 3.2% during the same period. More recently, government data shows female LFPR reaching 40% in 2025. Overall, India's LFPR for people aged 15 years and above stood at 55.9% in February 2026, indicating the expanding size of the country's active workforce.

Healthcare is one of the most significant arenas of women's contribution. Women are increasingly visible as doctors, nurses, researchers, hospital administrators, public-health professionals and healthcare entrepreneurs. India had 42.94 lakh registered nursing personnel as of March 2025

Education is another powerful engine of women's economic mobility. Female enrolment in higher education increased from 1.57 crore in 2014-15 to 2.24 crore in 2023-24, a rise of 42.2%. Female Gross Enrolment Ratio reached 31.2%, compared with 22.9% in 2014-15. Women now account for 54.9% of India's total school teaching workforce, making them a powerful force in shaping the next generation. Female postgraduate enrolment has also risen by more than 61% since 2014-15.

Entrepreneurship is perhaps the clearest expression of women-led growth. More than 10 crore women have been mobilised into Self-Help Groups, creating an enormous grassroots economic network. Female self-employment increased from 51.9% in 2017-18 to 67.4% in 2023-24. Nearly every second DPIIT-recognised startup has at least one woman director, while women have received 68% of loans under the Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana. The government has also reported 2 crore Lakhpati Didis, highlighting the scale of women's income-generating activity in rural India.

Government services are witnessing a gradual but important shift as well. Women are increasingly entering the IAS, IPS and other civil services, bringing greater gender diversity into policymaking and administration. In the UPSC Civil Services Examination 2024, 284 of the 1,009 candidates recommended for appointment were women, or about 28%. The 2025 IAS Civil List records 5,577 officers in active service, reflecting the scale of the administrative machinery in which women's representation continues to grow.

The story of Indian women is therefore no longer confined to one sector or one social class. It spans the rural entrepreneur, the corporate executive, the doctor, nurse, professor, teacher, scientist, IAS officer and startup founder.

India's next phase of growth will depend on converting this momentum into greater leadership, equal opportunities, higher incomes and stronger workforce participation. When women advance, they do not advance alone—they create jobs, educate families, strengthen communities and expand India's productive capacity.

The rise of women is not a parallel narrative to India's growth story. It is increasingly at the very centre of it.